Airtribe

Fundamentals of Product Management

Week-1

Product Management Roadmap

PHASE 1

CRAFT

Modules 1–4

1. Fundamentals of Product Management — WEEK 1
2. Product Strategy & Strategic Thinking
3. Problem Discovery, Market & User Research
4. Problem Framing & Prioritization

PHASE 2

CRAFT + AI

Modules 5–8

5. UX & Design Collaboration
6. Effective Communication as a PM
7. Analytics & Metrics
8. Product Launch, Growth & Monetization

PHASE 3

DEEP AI

Modules 9–13

9. Tech 101 & System Design
10. LLMs, RAGs & AI Foundations
11. Vibe Coding for PMs
12. Agentic AI & AI Systems in Production
13. Capstone Project & Interview Prep

What are we looking at today : Day 1

1. What's a product?
2. What's product management?
3. B2B vs. B2C PM
4. Product management now vs before
5. Stakeholder Management
6. Q&A



BASIC GUIDLINES

- Keep yourself on mute if you are not speaking
- Keep your cameras on!
- Engage on chat and feel free to speak your mind

Main takeaway: Fundamentals of product management

Learning outcome: Gain a foundational understanding of product management, product thinking, and AI-assisted problem-solving.

Group activity: You are a PM at a large ecommerce company and you have do a product thinking exercise for a case at hand.

Why PM Craft Comes Before AI

AI can speed up execution. But it cannot replace clear thinking, strong judgment, or deep user understanding.

Module 1 focus

Before AI becomes useful, a PM needs craft.

That means learning how to:

- identify real user problems
- think clearly about trade-offs
- tell a strong idea from a weak one
- write sharper problem statements

What AI amplifies

1. **Clear thinking**
   Can you define the problem properly?
2. **Judgment**
   Can you make the right trade-offs?
3. **User understanding**
   Can you tell what actually matters?

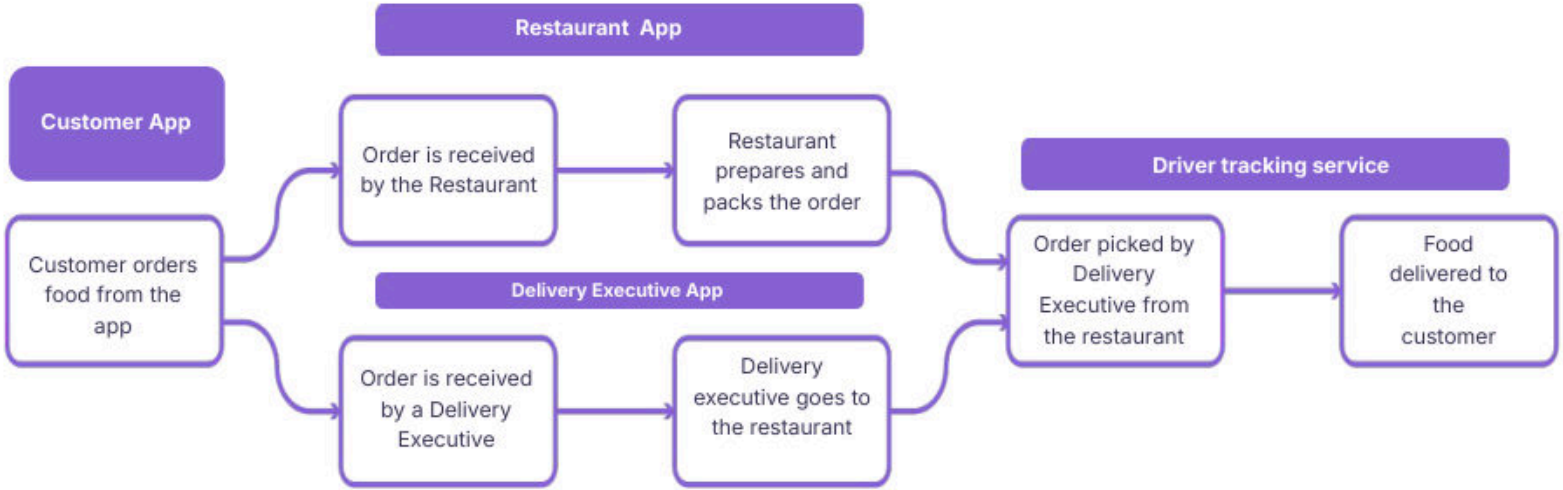
Bottom line: AI amplifies strong PMs. It also exposes weak product thinking.

What is a Product?



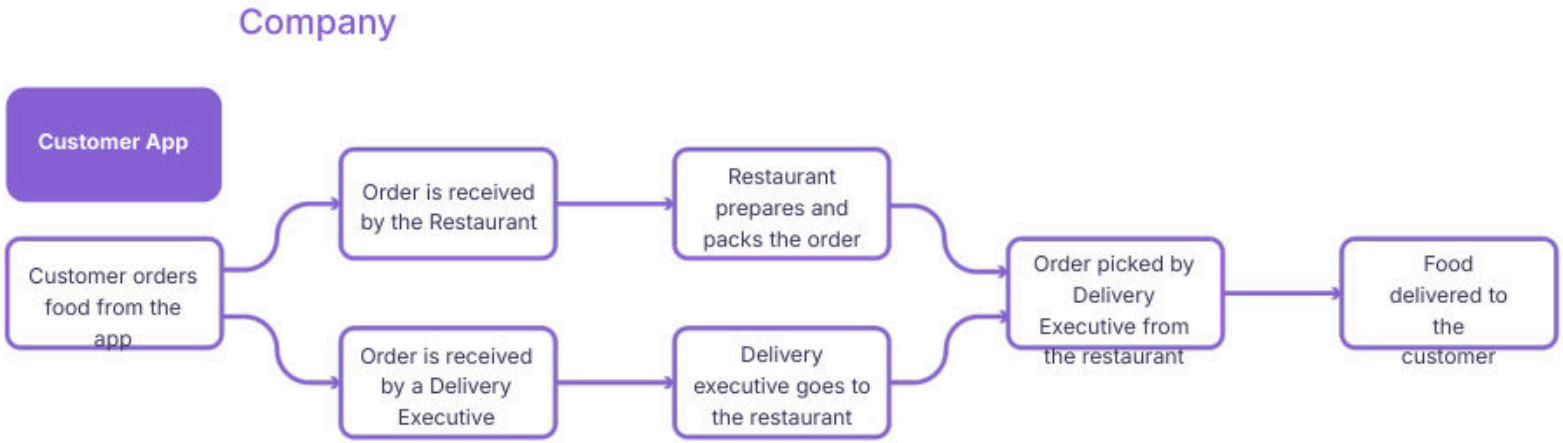
What is a Product?

Let's take an example: Food Delivery Company



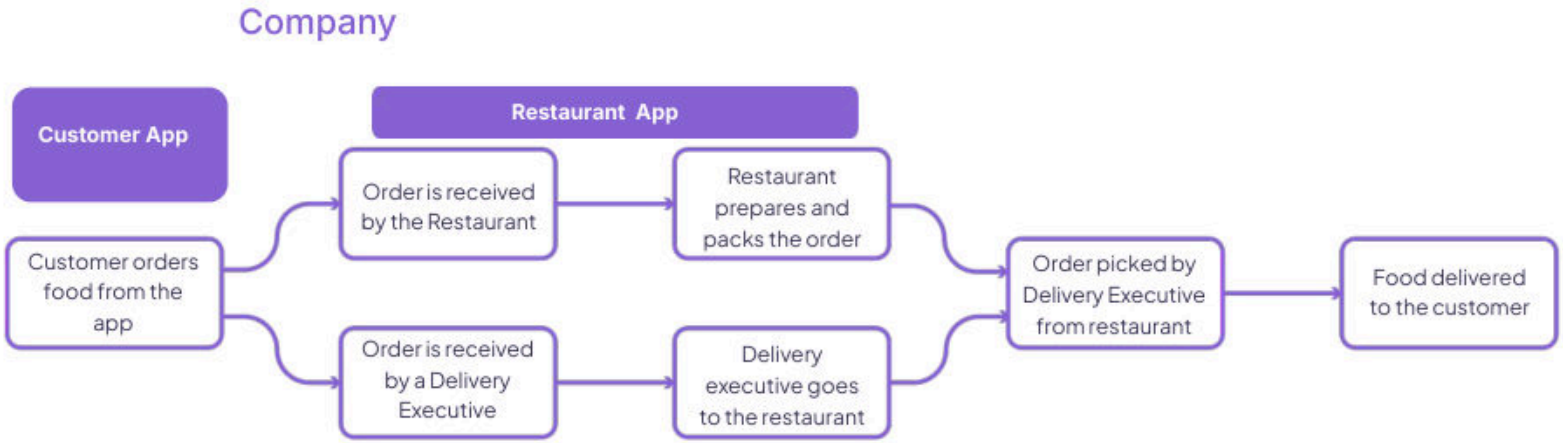
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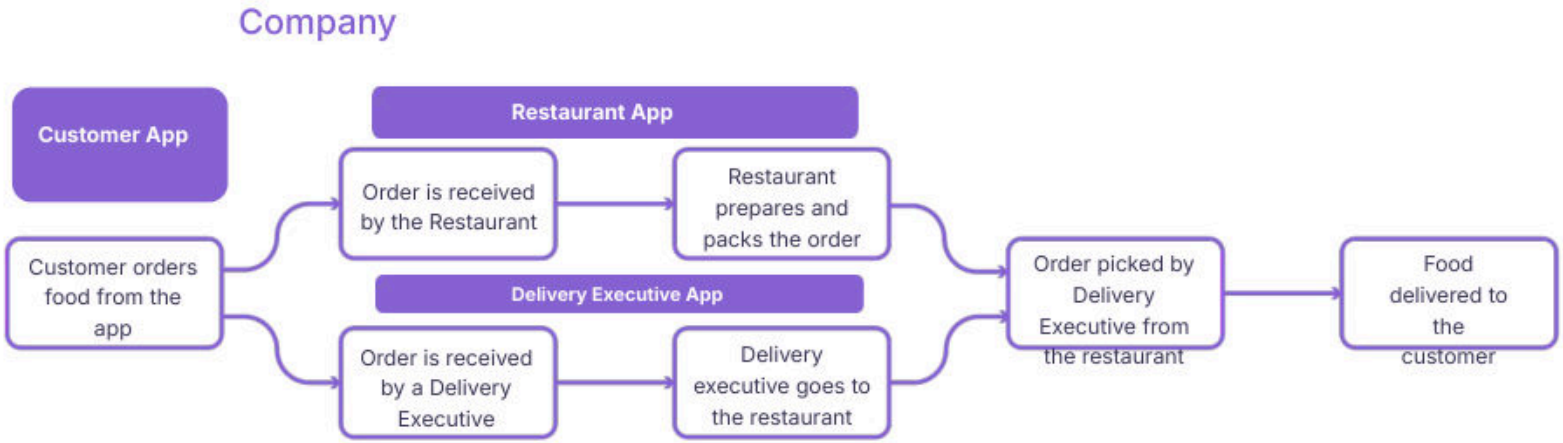
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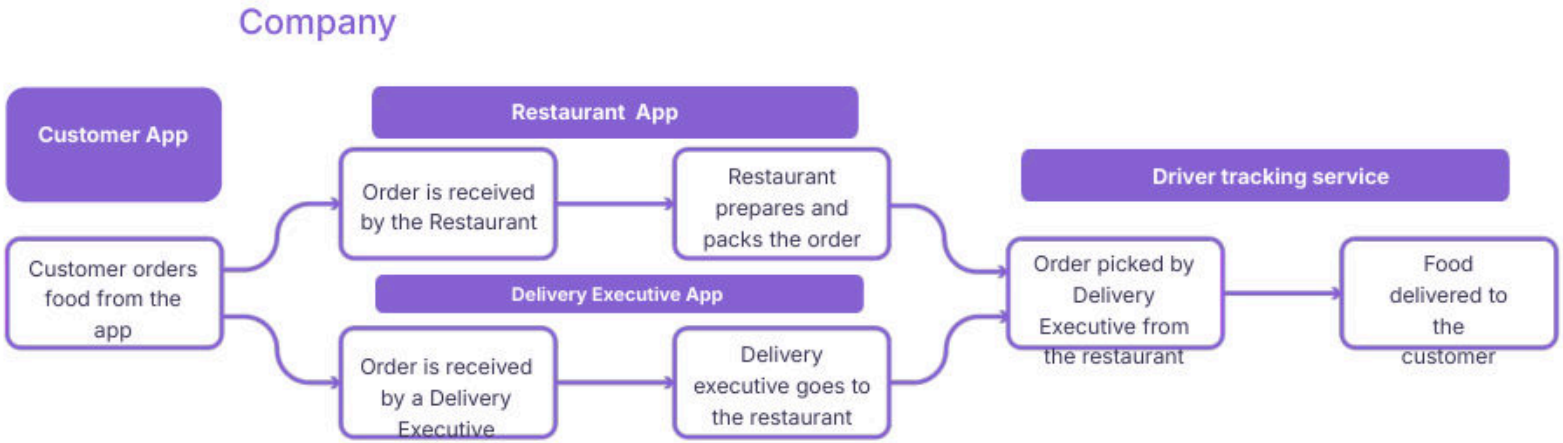
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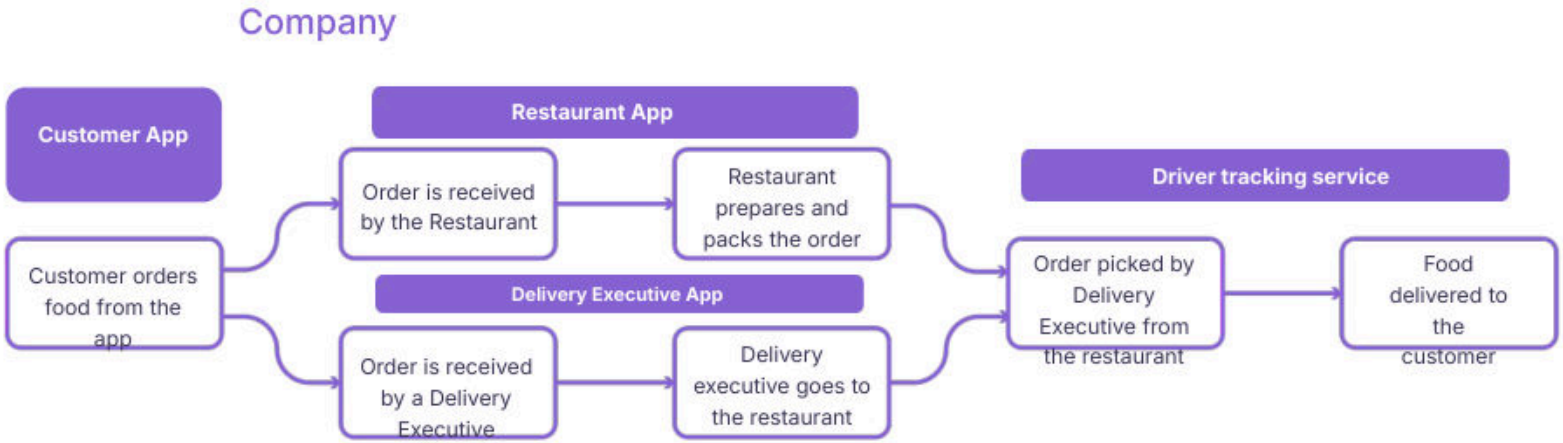
What is a Product?

Let's take an example: Food Delivery



What is a Product?

Let's take an example: Food Delivery



Let’s Define It Here

A product is a scalable solution that addresses a specific problem or need for a defined group of users, delivering value in a repeatable way.



Examples

PhonePe

PhonePe (B2C, Digital, Fintech)



Problem:

People needed a **fast, cashless** way to pay.

Examples

PhonePe

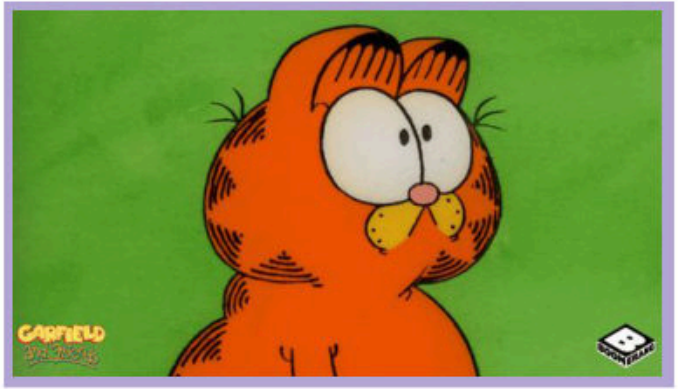
PhonePe (B2C, Digital, Fintech)

Solution:

UPI-based transactions made **digital payments seamless**.

What is Product Management?

In simplest terms, product management is about creating value for users and capturing value for the business.



B2B vs B2C Product Management

	B2B (Business to Business)	B2C (Business to Consumer)
Buyer	Committee: economic buyer, technical evaluator, champion, end user	Individual consumer making personal decisions
Sales Cycle	Months to years - demos, pilots, procurement, legal	Minutes to days - impulsive or low-effort decisions
Success Metrics	NRR, ARR, churn, activation, expansion revenue, health score	DAU/MAU, retention, conversion, revenue per user
Feedback Loops	Slow - quarterly reviews, CSM-mediated, multi-stakeholder	Fast - app store reviews, in-app surveys, usage data
Pricing	Negotiated contracts, enterprise pricing, usage-based tiers	Freemium, subscription, transactional

Examples



Swiggy/Zomato (B2C, Food Delivery)

✅ **Creating Value for Users:**

Users get **fast, convenient** food delivery from restaurants nearby.

✅ **Capturing Value for Business:**

Swiggy earns **commission from restaurants + delivery fees from users**.

Examples



Slack (B2B, SaaS)

✅ **Creating Value for Users:**

Teams communicate **efficiently** without email overload.

✅ **Capturing Value for Business:**

Slack earns **subscription revenue from enterprises**.

Q & A

Day in the Life of a PM



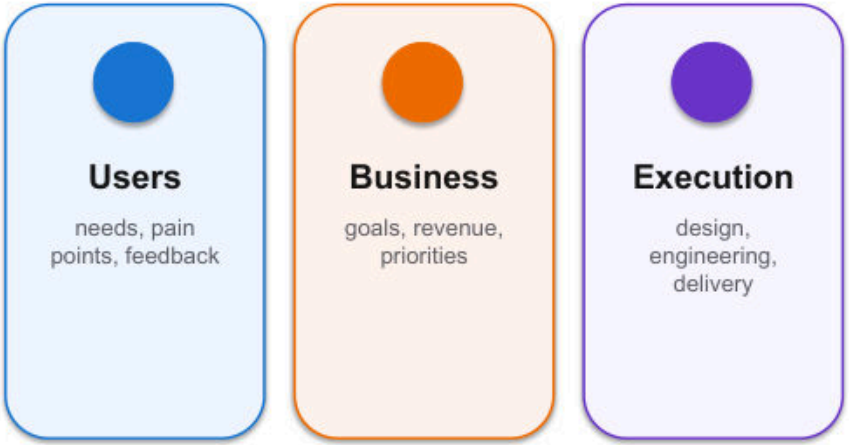
What Does a PM Actually Do Day to Day?

A PM's job is not just to write PRDs or attend meetings. It is to move a product forward by creating clarity across teams.

A typical PM day may include

1. **User inputs**
   Talk to users, review feedback, spot friction.
2. **Problem clarity**
   Define what matters and what can wait.
3. **Team alignment**
   Work with design, engineering, and business.
4. **Decision making**
   Review trade-offs, scope, and priorities.
5. **Measurement**
   Check metrics and decide what to improve next.

PMs sit at the intersection of



The PM connects all three and keeps the product moving.

Stakeholder Management Fundamentals

PMs don't build alone - they orchestrate across these teams



Engineering

Feasibility & estimates



Design

UX quality & user flows



Sales / Biz

Revenue & commitments



Marketing

Positioning & launch



Leadership

Vision & resources



Users

Voice, needs & feedback



Roadmap

Single source of truth



You (PM)

Orchestrator of all above

Skills Required for a PM



Product Thinking



Communication



Data & Metrics



Execution



Technology



Business Acumen

What's AI-First Product Management?

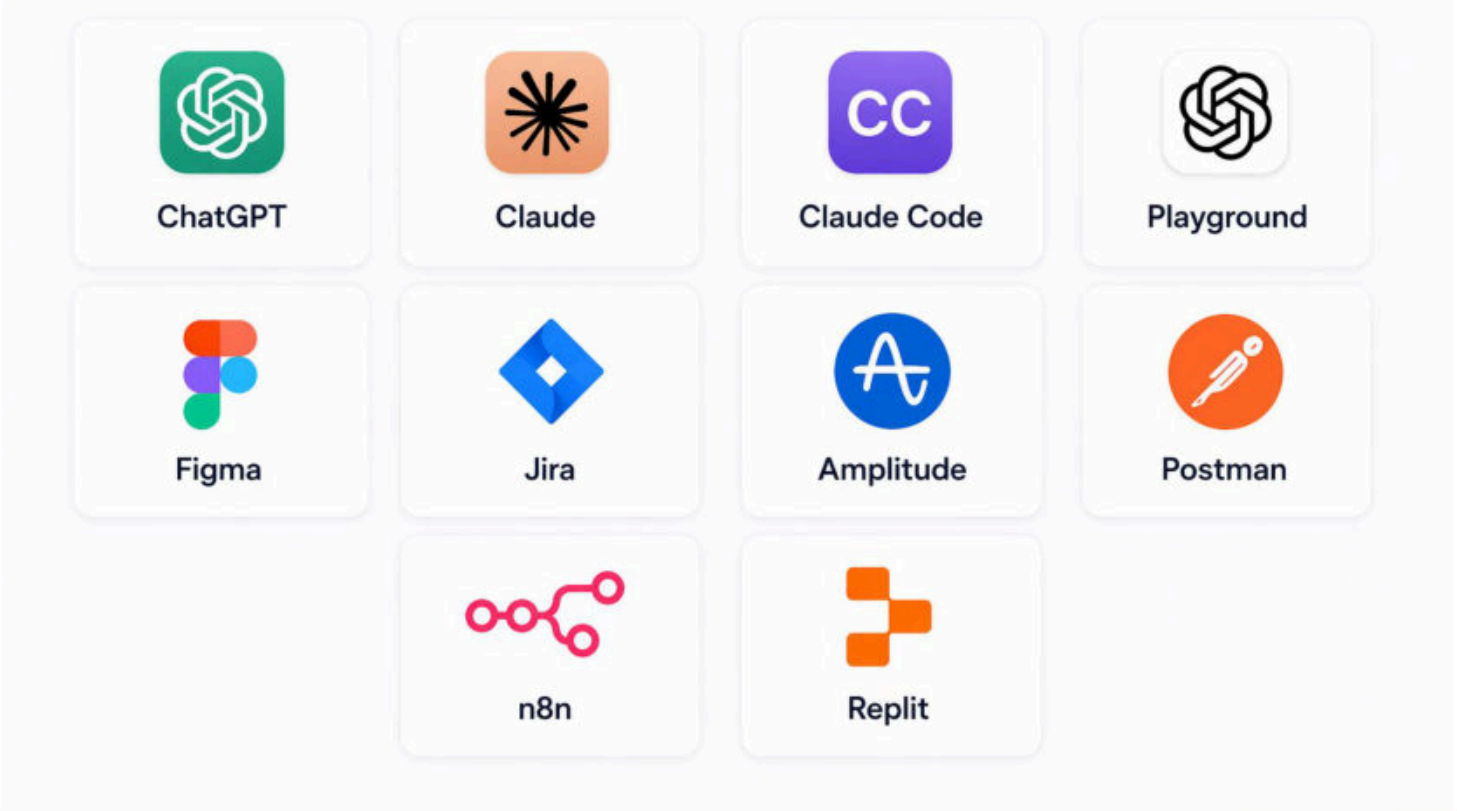
AI-First Product Management means using AI as a tool to help you at every stage of building a product—from understanding what users need, to building features, to helping the product grow.

It's about working smarter:

- using AI to get faster insights,
- come up with better ideas,
- and make more confident decisions.

You still need strong product thinking. AI just helps you move faster and go deeper.

AI Product Stack



Q & A

What are we looking at today : Day 2

1. Developing Product Sense
2. What's product thinking?
3. Talk to real people - not persona
4. Breakout room activity



BASIC GUIDLINES

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Product Thinking

“It is the skill of knowing what makes a product useful - and loved - by people.”

Julie Zhuo, ex-VP Design, Facebook



Product Thinking

It's not just about building features.*It's about asking:*

- **Who is this for?**
- **What problem are we solving?**
- **Why does this problem matter now?**
- **How do we know this is the right solution?**



Product Thinking

- This is the first step to building a product.
- It's a structured thinking exercise, it pushes you to spend more time on the problem space rather than solution space.
- It helps you build the right product for the right audience at the right time.

Product Thinking Framework

Problem Space

- **Goal:** What is the objective?
- **User Persona:** Who are my users?
- **User Journey:** What is their current experience?
- **Problem Identification:** What pain points or unmet needs exist?
- **Prioritization** : Which problems should we solve first?

Solution Space

- **Solutioning:** What is the best product solution for our prioritized problems?
- **Measurement & Iteration:** What are our success metrics, and how do we improve based on them?

Common Product Thinking Traps

1. Building the Wrong Product (Solution-First Thinking**)**

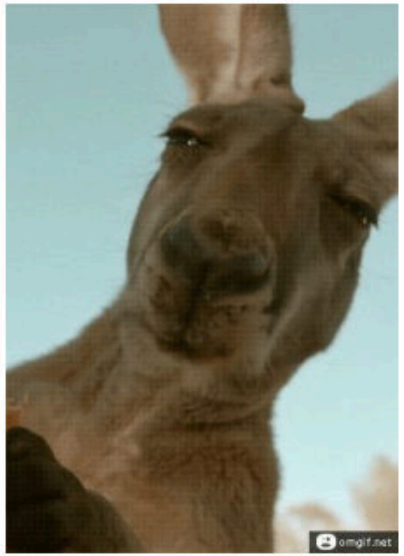
"Let's build a chatbot!"
Instead ask: ***"What problem are we solving?"***

2. Building for Everyone (Lack of Audience Focus**)**

"This feature will help all our users."
Instead ask: ***"Which segment is this really for?"***

3. Building at the Wrong Time (Poor Market Readiness**)**

"Online grocery will work—people always need groceries."
Instead ask: ***"Is the market ready for this solution right now?"***
ZopNow failed in 2009. Zepto thrived in 2022.



Product Sense: Good vs. Mediocre Products

Product sense is the ability to instinctively know what makes a product great - and what falls short.

✓ Great Products	✗ Mediocre Products
Solves one core problem exceptionally well	Tries to do everything, does nothing great
Feels obvious - users don't need a tutorial	Requires onboarding, help docs, and support calls
Gets better the more you use it (data + habit)	Same experience on day 1 and day 100
Users pull others in (word of mouth, virality)	Requires heavy marketing to acquire each user
Earns trust - transparent, reliable, private	Users feel manipulated or uncertain

Real Example: WhatsApp vs. early messaging apps. WhatsApp did one thing - simple, fast, cross-platform messaging. No clutter. No feature bloat. That clarity is product sense in action.

Developing Product Sense

Product sense isn't talent - it's a practice. Build it deliberately.

01



Use Products Intentionally

Ask 'why' every design decision. What trade-off was made here?

02



Do Product Teardowns

One product/week. Map the user journey. Brilliant + broken.

03



Form & Defend Opinions

'Feature X is a mistake because...' Reason out loud.

04



Read Launches Critically

Who is this for? Real insight or just a feature?

05



Talk to Non-PM Users

Casual conversations, not interviews. The world is a free focus group.

06



Write Down Your Opinions

Keep a product journal. Being wrong is more valuable.

Talk to a Real User – Not a Persona

The best PMs go to the source. Personas are hypotheses – real conversations are data.

YOUR MISSION (5 MINS)

Find 1 real person

friend, colleague, or family member who has experienced a genuine product frustration.

ASK THEM:

1. What were you trying to do?
2. What happened instead?
3. How did it make you feel?
4. What did you do next?

Listen. Don't pitch solutions. Don't interrupt.

Then write down exactly what they said — in their words, not yours.

EXAMPLE CONVERSATION



I just wanted to quickly order food after a long day.



But I kept scrolling through too many options.



It was frustrating and time consuming.



I closed the app and ordered from somewhere else.

Write exact quotes.
Word-for-word is your superpower.

AVOID THIS

- Asking leading questions ("Don't you think...")
- Jumping to solutions before understanding
- Talking more than listening

DO THIS

- Ask open-ended questions
- Listen fully and understand the context
- Write exact words, not interpretations

We'll discuss 2–3 responses live.
Be ready to share!



The Problem Statement Formula

Before you define a solution, define the problem precisely. One formula, every time.

[User] needs [outcome] because [insight]

[User]

Be specific. Not 'users' - a defined segment.

Example: *First-time home buyers aged 28–35 in metro cities*

[Outcome]

What they need to achieve - not what feature to build.

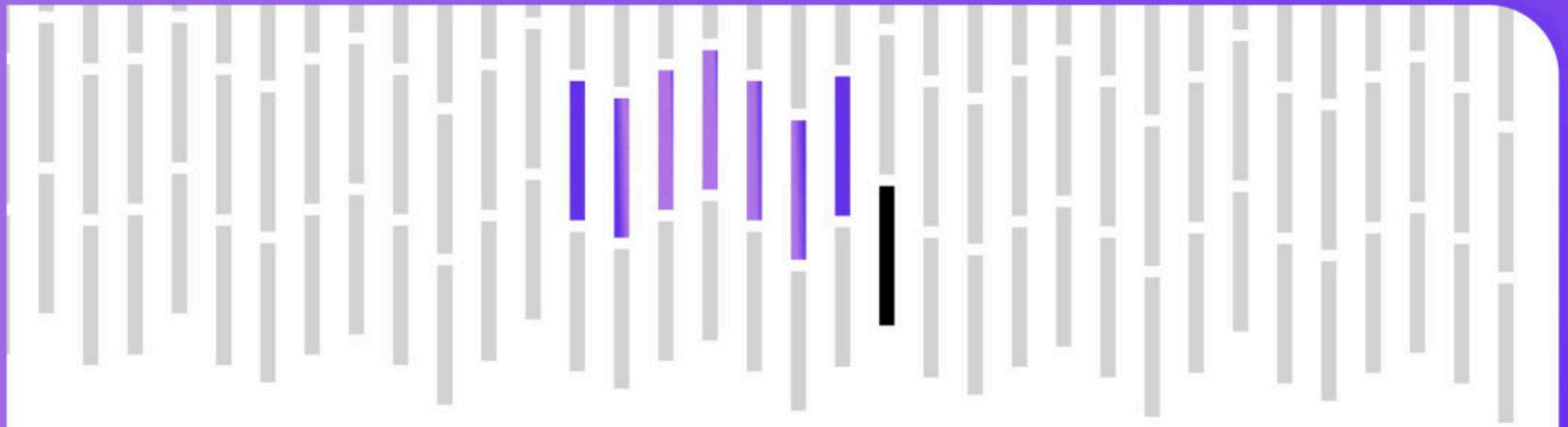
Example: *...need to understand their loan eligibility quickly...*

[Insight]

The 'why now' - evidence, behaviour, or root cause.

Example: *...because the current process requires 7 confusing steps and 3 days of waiting.*

Full statement: First-time home buyers (28–35, metros) need to understand loan eligibility quickly because the current process requires 7 confusing steps and 3 days of waiting.



Let’s do a breakout room activity!

Breakout Room Activity | Product Thinking (15 mins)



Scenario

Bistro by Blinkit: strong installs, good first orders
But low repeat usage (users don't return in 5–7 days)

Your Task

1. Who is the user?
Be specific

2. What are they trying to do?
Context matters

3. Why are they not coming back?
List 2–3 reasons

4. What's the biggest problem?

Pick one

5. Write a problem statement
[User] needs [outcome] because [insight]

Rule

Don't jump to solutions too early

Q & A

Take Home Assignment

Scenario:

Explore Nykaa with a clear goal (for example, buying a face mask, finding an lotion for dry skin, or casually browsing).

As you use the app, carefully note the steps you take and where the experience feels:
– Smooth
– Confusing
– Slow
– Frustrating
Break your journey into simple steps (like opening the app, searching, viewing a product, adding to cart, and checkout), and for each step, think about what the user is trying to do and what works well or doesn't.

Identify three specific features or experiences and form clear opinions by explaining whether you think they are good or bad and why.

Take Home Assignment

Speak to two people who are not from a product or design background and ask about their experience using Nykaa, what they like, dislike, and any reasons they may have dropped off without purchasing.

Finally, reflect on what you observed that you usually ignore, whether your perspective changed after talking to users, and what you found most challenging in this exercise.

Q & A